

MEMES : THE MODERN INFLUENCE ON PUBLIC PERCEPTION

*A Project Report Submitted to “JNTU-GV, Vizianagaram” For Fulfillment of
Requirements for Award of Degree of*

**Bachelor of Technology
in
Computer Science & Engineering (DS)
(With Specialization In Liberal Arts)**

By

GANTI LAKSHMI HARIKA (21NU1A4411)

**Under the Guidance
of**

**DR. PRASANTHI MUSINANA
Associate Professor**



**Department of Computer Science and Engineering (DS)
Nadimpalli Satyanarayana Raju Institute of Technology
(AUTONOMOUS)**

(Permanently to JNTU-GV, Vizianagaram, Approved by AICTE, New Delhi)

Sontyam, Visakhapatnam-531173

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DECLARATION

I certify that the work contained in this report is original and has been done by me under the guidance of my supervisor Dr.Prasanthi Musinana, Associate Professor Department of S & H. The work has not been submitted to any other Institute for any degree or diploma. I have followed the guidelines provided by the Institute in preparing the report. I have conformed to the norms and guidelines given in the Ethical Code of Conduct of the Institute. Whenever I have used materials (data, theoretical analysis, figures, and text) from other sources, I have given due credit to them by citing them in the text of the report and giving their details in the references. Further, I have taken permission from the copyright owners of the sources, whenever necessary.

Place: Visakhapatnam

Date:

**GANTI LAKSHMI HARIKA
(21NU1A4411)**

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the project report entitled “**MEMES : THE MODERN INFLUENCE ON PUBLIC PERCEPTION**” submitted by **G.LAKSHMI HARIKA (21NU1A4411)** to the Nadimpalli Satyanarayana Raju Institute of Technology, Sontyam, Visakhapatnam in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the Minors Degree in **Liberal Arts** is a bonafide record of work carried out by him/her under my/our guidance and supervision. The contents of this report, in full or in parts, have not been submitted to any other Institute for the award of any Degree.

Internal Guide

Dr.Prasanthi Musinana

Associate Professor

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Head of the Department

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External Examiner

Date

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I would like to take this opportunity to express my deepest gratitude to my project supervisor, **DR. PRASANTHI MUSINANA**, Associate Professor Department of S & H, N S Raju Institute of Technology (A), Visakhapatnam, who has persistently and determinedly guided me during the whole course of this project. It would have been very difficult to complete this project without her enthusiastic support, insight and advice. We are extremely thankful to **Dr. S. VENKATESAN**, Associate Professor & Head of Computer Science & Engineering (DS) Department for providing excellent lab facilities which were helpful in successful completion of my project. Our utmost thanks to our project coordinator DR. PRASANTHI MUSINANA, Associate Professor Department of S & H for her support throughout our project work.

We take immense pleasure in thanking **Dr. S. Sambhu Prasad**, Principal, **Dr.P.S.Raju**, CMO, N S Raju Institute of Technology (A), Sontyam, and Visakhapatnam, for having permitted us to finish the project work. We thank the Management of N S Raju Institute of Technology (A), Sontyam, Visakhapatnam, for providing the various resources to complete the project successfully. We are thankful to one and all who contributed to my work directly or indirectly.

List of Program Outcomes

As per the Program of Study

- PO1: Apply the knowledge of basic sciences and fundamental engineering concepts in solving engineering problems **(Engineering Knowledge)**
- PO2: Identify, formulate, review research literature, and analyze complex engineering problems reaching substantiated conclusions using first principles of mathematics, natural sciences, and engineering sciences. **(Problem Analysis)**
- PO3: Design solutions for complex engineering problems and design system components or processes that meet the specified needs with appropriate consideration for the public health and safety, and the cultural, societal, and environmental considerations. **(Design/Development of Solutions)**
- PO4: Perform investigations, design and conduct experiments, analyse and interpret the results to provide valid conclusions **(Investigation of Complex Problems)**
- PO5: Select/develop and apply appropriate techniques and IT tools for the design & analysis of the systems **(Modern Tool Usage)**
- PO6: Give reasoning and assess societal, health, legal and cultural issues with competency in professional engineering practices **(The Engineer and Society)**
- PO7: Demonstrate professional skills and contextual reasoning to assess environmental/societal issues for sustainable development **(The Environment and Sustainability)**
- PO8: Demonstrate Knowledge of professional and ethical practices **(Ethics)**
- PO9: Function effectively as an individual, and as a member or leader in diverse teams, and in multi-disciplinary situations **(Individual and Team Work)**
- PO10: Communicate effectively among engineering community, being able to comprehend and write effectively reports, presentation and give / receive clear instructions **(Communication)**
- PO11: Demonstrate and apply engineering & management principles in their own / team projects in multidisciplinary environment **(Project Finance and Management)**
- PO12: Recognize the need for, and have the ability to engage in independent and lifelong learning **(Life Long Learning)**

LIST OF PROGRAM SPECIFIC OUTCOMES

- PSO1: Design and develop intelligent systems by applying analytical and programming skills to solve real world and engineering problems
- PSO2: Ability to apply the knowledge of computing tools and techniques in the field of Data Science for solving real world problems encountered in the Software Industries maintaining the professional standards and ethics.

DEPARTMENT OF COMPUTER SCIENCE & ENGINEERING (DATA SCIENCE)

VISION:

To become the centre of excellence for technically competent and innovative computer engineers.

MISSION:

- To provide quality education and spread professional and technical knowledge, leading to a career as computer professionals in different domains of industry, governance, and academia.
- To provide a state-of-the-art environment for learning and practices.
- To impact hands-on training in latest methodologies and technologies.

ABSTRACT

In recent years, memes have transcended their status as mere internet jokes to become influential cultural artifacts that shape and reflect public perception on a global scale. These user-generated images, videos, or texts, often humorous in nature carry powerful messages that are quickly disseminated through social media platforms, making them key tools for communication in the digital era. Memes have evolved into a modern form of rhetoric, influencing opinions on politics, social issues, consumer behavior, and even public policy. Their simplicity, relatability, and emotional appeal allow them to bypass traditional media filters, making them accessible and persuasive to a wide audience.

This paper delves into how memes operate as instruments of influence, exploring their psychological impact, the mechanisms of their virality, and their role in framing narratives. It also highlights how memes can be weaponized for propaganda or misinformation, making them double-edged swords in the information age. By analyzing case studies and trends, the study reveals the extent to which memes contribute to discourse formation, collective identity, and the perception of truth in online communities. Furthermore, the paper discusses the ethical challenges and societal responsibilities associated with meme culture, emphasizing the need for media literacy in navigating the digital landscape.

Keywords: Memes, Public Perception, Social Media, Digital Culture, Virality, Misinformation, Online Discourse, Psychological Influence, Internet Trends, Media Literacy

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INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

The evolution of communication in the digital age has transformed the way individuals interact, consume information, and shape opinions. With the widespread accessibility of the internet and the explosive growth of social media platforms, content creation and sharing have become decentralized and democratized. Within this new landscape, one of the most significant and influential phenomena to emerge is the internet meme. Memes, once considered trivial or merely humorous online artifacts, have matured into potent instruments of social expression, communication, and influence. These small units of culture—often consisting of images, videos, text, or a combination carry symbolic meanings that resonate across broad audiences, frequently going viral within hours or days.

Originally coined by evolutionary biologist Richard Dawkins in 1976 to describe cultural transmission, the term "meme" has taken on a new life in the context of digital culture. Today, internet memes function as snapshots of public sentiment, encapsulating emotions, criticisms, and ideas in a format that is easily digestible and widely shareable. Their power lies in their simplicity, relatability, and ability to connect people across geographical and ideological divides. From light-hearted jokes and viral challenges to biting political satire and social commentary, memes reflect collective consciousness and often shape it in subtle but profound ways.

In recent years, memes have increasingly been used as tools for raising awareness, challenging societal norms, and even spreading misinformation. Political campaigns, social movements, and advocacy groups now regularly employ memes to engage younger audiences and amplify their messages. At the same time, the humorous and informal nature of memes can mask their deeper psychological and cultural impacts, allowing them to influence attitudes and behaviors under the radar. As a result, the role of memes in shaping public perception has become a topic of academic interest. Understanding how memes influence thinking, behavior, and discourse is crucial in an era where digital content can spread faster and farther than ever before. This study seeks to explore the multifaceted influence of memes on public perception and what their growing presence reveals about the changing nature of media, identity, and information consumption in the 21st century.

1.2 Problem Statement

In today's digitally connected world, the way individuals form opinions and engage with information has fundamentally shifted. The rise of social media platforms has given birth to a new language of communication memes. Initially dismissed as simple, humorous content, memes have evolved into influential digital artifacts that possess the power to shape public discourse, spread awareness, and influence societal attitudes. However, this increasing influence has brought with it a complex set of problems that are often ignored or misunderstood by both the general public and academic researchers.

A key issue lies in the dual nature of memes. On one hand, they are powerful tools for social expression, activism, and community engagement. On the other, they are equally capable of spreading misinformation, reinforcing stereotypes, and promoting divisive ideologies. The very characteristics that make memes effective brevity, humor, relatability, and virality also make them difficult to regulate and easy to misuse. Audiences, especially younger users, are frequently exposed to a high volume of meme content, often consuming it passively without questioning its credibility, intent, or broader implications.

Furthermore, memes can blur the lines between fact and opinion, joke and propaganda. Because they are often perceived as "harmless fun," memes can manipulate emotions and shape beliefs without raising suspicion. This subtle influence is especially concerning in political, social, and cultural contexts, where public perception plays a critical role in decision-making and societal development. Memes can frame narratives, control discourse, and create echo chambers where misinformation thrives unchecked.

Despite their widespread use and impact, there is a noticeable lack of scholarly attention on how memes function as tools of influence in the digital information ecosystem. There is a pressing need to investigate how memes affect public thinking, behavior, and awareness, particularly in terms of psychological impact and media literacy. As communication continues to evolve, understanding the influence of memes becomes not just relevant but essential. This study aims to explore these overlooked dimensions and contribute to a broader understanding of digital media's role in shaping modern public perception.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The primary objective of this study is to critically examine how internet memes influence public perception in the context of modern digital communication. As memes continue to gain popularity across various online platforms, their role in shaping opinions, spreading messages, and influencing attitudes warrants thorough investigation. The study aims to explore the mechanisms through which memes exert social and psychological influence, and how they contribute to the construction of contemporary narratives on cultural, political, and societal issues.

One of the key objectives is to analyze the communicative power of memes and understand how their structure often humorous, symbolic, and brief makes them effective tools for mass communication. This includes investigating how users interpret memes, what makes them relatable, and how certain themes or formats gain viral traction. Through this analysis, the study seeks to uncover the persuasive elements embedded in meme culture and how these elements guide or distort public understanding.

Another important goal is to assess the dual impact of memes: their potential to raise awareness and promote social engagement, as well as their capacity to spread misinformation, reinforce stereotypes, or normalize harmful ideologies. By studying both positive and negative implications, the research aims to present a balanced view of meme influence, highlighting the responsibilities of creators and the importance of critical consumption by audiences.

The study also aims to evaluate the role of memes in digital activism, political campaigns, and social movements. It seeks to understand how memes are strategically used by individuals, groups, and institutions to influence public discourse and mobilize support. In doing so, the research will provide insights into the effectiveness of memes as tools for advocacy and persuasion in an increasingly media-saturated society.

Lastly, the study intends to promote the importance of media literacy in the age of viral content. By identifying the psychological and emotional triggers that make memes influential, the research encourages a more informed and reflective approach to meme

consumption. It aims to equip individuals—especially young, frequent internet users with the awareness needed to critically analyze digital content and recognize the broader impact memes can have on personal beliefs and societal attitudes.

In summary, this study sets out to:

- Investigate the communicative and persuasive features of memes.
- Explore the psychological and social impact of meme consumption.
- Assess the dual role of memes in spreading both information and misinformation.
- Examine the strategic use of memes in activism, politics, and public discourse.
- Promote critical thinking and media literacy in the digital age.

1.4 Scope of the Study

This study focuses on understanding the influence of internet memes on public perception within the broader framework of digital communication and online culture. The research primarily investigates how memes through their structure, content, and circulation—affect the way individuals interpret information, form opinions, and engage in public discourse. By examining both the psychological and sociocultural dimensions of meme consumption, the study aims to offer a comprehensive view of the role memes play in shaping modern thought and behavior.

The scope of the study is limited to digital platforms where memes are most commonly created, shared, and interacted with. These platforms include social media networks such as Facebook, Instagram, Twitter (X), Reddit, and TikTok. The study focuses on user-generated content that becomes viral or widely circulated within these spaces. While memes exist in various forms (images, GIFs, videos, texts), the study emphasizes those that have a clear message or theme related to public opinion, social issues, politics, or cultural trends.

Geographically, the study emphasizes meme culture as it manifests in a globalized digital context but draws specific attention to English-language memes, as these dominate the international meme landscape and are widely accessible. However, references to regional variations and cultural adaptations of memes are also acknowledged when relevant. The time frame of the study focuses on memes circulated predominantly over the last five to seven years, a period that coincides with increased global digital connectivity and the explosion of meme-based communication.

In terms of demographics, while the study acknowledges that memes are consumed by diverse age groups, it places particular emphasis on youth and young adults (ages 15–35), who are the most active participants in meme culture. This focus is essential, as younger audiences are often more susceptible to online influence and are deeply immersed in the social media environments where memes thrive.

The study does not aim to provide a technical analysis of meme creation tools or the algorithms that control content visibility on social platforms. Instead, it concentrates on the interpretive and societal effects of memes as communicative texts. Similarly, the study does not analyze memes from a purely linguistic or comedic perspective, but rather from a media, cultural, and psychological standpoint.

In conclusion, the scope of this study encompasses:

- The influence of memes on public perception and opinion.
- The platforms and digital spaces where meme culture is most active.
- The role of memes in relation to social, political, and cultural topics.
- The behavioral and interpretive responses of audiences, especially youth.
- The broader societal implications of viral meme content.

LITERATURE REVIEW

The rise of internet memes as a form of digital communication has garnered significant attention in recent years, both in academic and popular discourse. Scholars from various fields, including communication studies, psychology, sociology, and media studies, have begun to examine the influence of memes on public perception and their growing impact on social behavior. This literature review synthesizes key contributions to the understanding of memes, focusing on their role as communicative tools, their psychological effects, and their influence on societal values and public discourse.

One of the foundational works on memes is Richard Dawkins' *The Selfish Gene* (1976), in which he introduced the concept of the "meme" as a unit of cultural transmission. Although Dawkins' original theory was based on biological evolution, his concept has been adapted to digital media studies to understand the viral nature of online content. In the context of internet memes, scholars such as Shifman (2014) in *Memes in Digital Culture* argue that memes function as a modern form of cultural currency. Shifman's work explores how memes can be seen as shared social artifacts, carrying meanings that reflect societal norms, political ideologies, and collective sentiments.

The psychological influence of memes has also been a major focus in recent studies. According to Berger and Milkman (2012), viral content is not simply about popularity, but also about how emotional engagement drives people to share. Memes, which often evoke humor or strong emotional reactions, are particularly effective at encouraging social sharing. This emotional appeal, according to the research, can shape public perception by reinforcing existing beliefs or challenging dominant narratives. Such findings are corroborated by studies like those by Khamis, Ang, and Welling (2017), who highlight the role of memes in shaping political opinions, especially during moments of crisis or societal upheaval.

The role of memes in shaping political discourse and activism is another well-explored area in the literature. Howard and Hussain (2013) argue that social media, including the use of memes, has revolutionized political communication by enabling grassroots movements to spread ideas more rapidly and widely than ever before. For instance, memes have played a pivotal role in political movements such as the Arab Spring and, more recently, in the U.S. presidential elections, where they have been used to both support and criticize candidates. This phenomenon of "political meme warfare" is further explored by Tufekci (2017), who examines how memes function in the digital public sphere as tools for political mobilization, propaganda, and counter-narratives.

In contrast, other researchers have explored the darker side of meme culture, particularly its role in spreading misinformation and fostering divisive rhetoric.

Despite these challenges, some scholars emphasize the potential of memes to engage audiences in meaningful social change. For example, studies by Gerbaudo (2018) demonstrate how memes can empower marginalized groups by giving them a voice in digital spaces, fostering community-building and collective action.

These studies highlight the potential for memes to act as agents of social commentary, helping to shed light on pressing issues like racial inequality, gender identity, and environmental activism.

Furthermore, meme culture's impact on media literacy has also become a subject of concern in recent years. As memes play an increasingly prominent role in shaping public perception, scholars like Buckingham (2003) stress the need for greater media literacy in the digital age.

In summary, the literature on memes highlights their multifaceted role in modern communication, ranging from their use as tools for entertainment and social commentary to their potential for spreading misinformation and influencing political and social movements. As memes continue to evolve and permeate digital spaces, their influence on public perception remains an important area of study, with implications for media literacy, societal values, and the future of online communication.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

The research design for this study is descriptive and quantitative, aiming to examine how memes influence public perception in the context of digital culture, social media, and internet trends. The study focuses on identifying patterns and correlations between cognitive biases, emotional responses, and social influences that drive individuals to engage with memes. It will explore how certain types of memes shape attitudes, beliefs, and behavior across different demographics, particularly among younger internet users.

This study will analyze various psychological factors, such as humor, social validation, group dynamics, and political bias, that contribute to the widespread appeal and virality of memes. Additionally, it will investigate how memes influence public discourse, particularly regarding sensitive or controversial topics, and their potential to propagate misinformation or reinforce existing biases.

To collect data, participants will be surveyed on their exposure to and engagement with memes, as well as their emotional and cognitive responses to different types of content. The survey will assess how often participants encounter memes, how they perceive them, and how memes influence their opinions or attitudes on various social and political issues. The goal is to identify trends and correlations between meme consumption and public perception without attempting to establish direct cause-and-effect relationships.

The research design will offer insights into how memes function as vehicles of cultural transmission and how they influence the way individuals interpret and interact with the world around them. The findings will contribute to a deeper understanding of the role memes play in shaping modern public perception, especially in the digital age..

3.2 Tools for Data Collection

To collect comprehensive data for the research on the psychology behind the obsession with memes in media, **Google Forms** will be used as the primary tool for data collection.

Google Forms is selected due to its ease of use, flexibility, and convenience in distributing surveys to a large and diverse group of participants. It also facilitates quick analysis and management of responses, making it an efficient choice for this study.

The questionnaire will be carefully structured to explore various aspects of the participants' psychological motivations and behaviors regarding their obsession with memes . The following key sections will be included in the questionnaire:

1. **Demographic Information:** This section will gather basic demographic data from participants, including their age, gender, education level, and frequency of social media use. Age and gender are important variables to understand the cross-sectional differences in how different groups engage with and interpret memes. Educational background may provide insights into the intellectual engagement with certain types of memes, as well as the role of education in shaping the way individuals process humor, sarcasm, or social commentary within meme culture. The frequency of social media use will be measured to assess how immersion in digital environments contributes to meme exposure and engagement..
2. **General Perception :** Participants will indicate how often they encounter and share memes across different platforms, such as Instagram, Twitter, and Facebook. This section will also gauge their emotional responses to memes, including humor, amusement, or discomfort.
3. **Psychological Influences:** The survey will include questions about cognitive biases (e.g., confirmation bias) and emotional reactions (e.g., amusement or outrage) to specific meme types. Participants will be asked how they think memes shape their opinions, particularly on political or societal issues.
4. **Emotional and Cognitive Responses:** This section of the study will examine how different emotional and cognitive processes influence the consumption of memes, as well as how memes themselves evoke distinct emotional responses from individuals. Memes often rely on humor, satire, shock value, or sarcasm to engage audiences, but they can also provoke negative emotions like anger, frustration, or sadness. This section will explore how participants emotionally react to various meme types, particularly those that address controversial topics or challenge social norms.
5. **Social and Cultural Influence:** The social and cultural context section will explore the influence of social media networks and peer groups in the spread of memes. Memes often circulate within tight-knit online communities, where they can evolve and gain traction based on shared group values and norms. This section will investigate how memes reinforce group identity. This section will also explore the role of memes in creating or fostering group dynamics, such as the sense of belonging in niche communities .

6. **Personal Experiences with Memes:** Open-ended questions will encourage participants to share their personal experiences, such as how they became interested in memes , their most memorable encounters with memes stories, and how these stories have affected their worldview or emotions. This section will provide rich qualitative data that offers deeper insights into individual motivations.

By collecting both quantitative and qualitative data, this approach will help to uncover the psychological, emotional, and social factors that contribute to the widespread fascination with memes content. The findings from the survey will contribute to a better understanding of why individuals are so drawn to these stories .

3.3 Sampling Technique

For this research on the influence of memes on public perception, a convenience sampling method will be employed. This approach involves selecting participants who are easily accessible and willing to participate, with a focus on individuals who actively engage with social media platforms where memes are prevalent. Given the wide reach of memes across various social media platforms, the study will target participants who are familiar with and regularly encounter memes.

The convenience sampling method is particularly suitable for this research because it allows the collection of data from a large, diverse group of individuals quickly and efficiently. Since the study does not aim for random sampling, it will focus on capturing a wide range of demographic groups, ensuring that participants vary in age, gender, cultural background, and social media habits. This variation will help in understanding how different groups interact with and are influenced by memes.

The sample will be recruited through online channels, particularly social media groups, mailing lists, and academic forums, where meme culture thrives. These platforms allow for easy distribution of the survey, making it accessible to a broader audience, particularly. Efforts will be made to ensure a diverse sample, but since convenience sampling does not involve random selection, there may be limitations regarding how well the sample represents the general population.

To improve the diversity of the sample, various demographic factors such as age, gender, and social media usage patterns will be considered. For example, the study will include

participants from different age groups (e.g., teenagers, young adults, and older individuals) to assess generational differences in meme consumption.

Anonymity and privacy will be prioritized throughout the sampling process. They will be informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any point without any consequences. This ethical consideration will help ensure that participants feel comfortable providing honest and unbiased responses, contributing to the integrity and reliability of the data.

3.4 Case Studies

3.4.1 Case Study 1: The Distracted Boyfriend Meme

Overview

The "Distracted Boyfriend" meme, originating from a stock photo of a man looking at another woman while his girlfriend looks on disapprovingly, became one of the most viral memes in 2017. It quickly transcended its original context and became a versatile tool for social commentary, humor, and satire. Its widespread use to depict various types of distractions and temptations sparked conversations about the nature of attention and relationships in the digital age.

Key Details

True Meme Elements

The meme's template can be used to depict many scenarios, representing situations of disloyalty, distractions, or shifting allegiances in a humorous or ironic manner. The photo became a cultural icon, symbolizing various social and personal dynamics.

Psychological Factors

The humor in the meme appeals to the universal experience of distraction, a feeling many individuals can relate to, whether it pertains to romantic relationships, work, or personal interests. It also taps into the concept of "moral judgment," as people often use the meme to discuss or criticize others' priorities.

Social Influence

The meme rapidly spread across different platforms and became part of mainstream discourse, reflecting social attitudes toward attention and commitment. It even led to discussions about how the meme represents society's changing views on relationships in the context of social media.

Impact

This meme influenced both online discussions and real-life social perceptions, creating a new

lens through which people discuss commitment, infidelity, and distraction. It became so popular that it was adapted into political memes, advertisements, and corporate marketing campaigns.

Response

Humorous Reactions: Many users found it hilarious due to the dramatic expression of the girlfriend and the relatable nature of shifting interests. Memes in this format resonated with people's personal experiences of temptation or distraction.

Political and Social Commentary: Others used it to comment on political shifts, representing how public attention often drifts away from pressing issues in favor of more sensational distractions.

3.4.2 Case Study : The “Woman Yelling at a Cat” Meme

Overview

The “Woman Yelling at a Cat” meme pairs a scene from *The Real Housewives of Beverly Hills* with a photo of a confused-looking cat named Smudge sitting at a dinner table. Emerging in 2019, this meme became an instant classic for representing arguments or dramatic overreactions met with confused indifference, offering a humorous portrayal of miscommunication and overreaction.

Key Details

- **True Meme Elements**

This meme juxtaposes two images with contrasting emotions: a woman visibly upset and yelling, and a cat appearing bewildered. It's used to illustrate everyday arguments, misunderstandings, or disagreements with humorous absurdity.

- **Psychological Factors**

The meme appeals to emotional contrast—dramatic expression versus indifferent calm. It reflects cognitive dissonance and highlights how people often respond emotionally while others remain unaffected. The relatability of irrational arguments enhances its comedic appeal.

- **Social Influence**

The meme went viral on Twitter, Reddit, and Instagram, frequently adapted for social, political, and cultural commentary. It became a favorite for illustrating generational, ideological, and relationship-based arguments.

- **Impact**

Beyond humor, the meme became a way to visually express frustration and disconnect, especially in online debates. It was also used in merchandising, digital stickers, and fan art.

Response

- **Humorous Reactions:** Audiences appreciated the exaggerated emotional divide, leading to countless parodies and spin-offs. The cat, Smudge, gained a cult following and its own fan pages.
- **Social Commentary:** It was widely used to critique unreasonable behavior, double standards, or exaggerated responses in public discourse.
- **Criticism:** Some felt the meme minimized the emotions of women, sparking conversations about gendered portrayals of emotion in media.

3.4.3 Case Study 3: The “OK Boomer” Meme

Overview

The “OK Boomer” meme emerged as a succinct rebuttal to attitudes perceived as outdated, particularly those expressed by Baby Boomers. Gaining momentum in 2019, it quickly became symbolic of generational tension and a tool for Gen Z and Millennials to challenge traditional views on climate change, social norms, and technology.

Key Details

- **True Meme Elements**

As a phrase, “OK Boomer” was used both seriously and humorously. It represents a sarcastic dismissal of advice or opinions seen as disconnected from modern realities. It appeared in memes, videos, tweets, and protest signs.

- **Psychological Factors**

The meme reflects generational identity and uses humor as a coping mechanism for frustration. It taps into cognitive biases such as *ingroup favoritism* and *confirmation bias*, reinforcing younger generations' shared perspectives.

- **Social Influence**

The meme spread rapidly on TikTok, Twitter, and Instagram, often used in discussions

around social justice, housing affordability, and job market challenges. It became a symbol of youth defiance.

- **Impact**

“OK Boomer” was even used in parliamentary debates and media interviews, sparking intergenerational dialogue and backlash. It highlighted social divides and drew attention to young people’s concerns.

Response

- **Empowerment for Youth:** Many saw it as a voice for younger generations, finally able to push back against outdated criticisms.
- **Media Frenzy:** It led to widespread debates in news outlets, some calling it ageist, while others defended it as satire.
- **Cultural Shift:** It marked a growing confidence among Gen Z and Millennials in using humor to express dissatisfaction.

3.4.4 Case Study 4: Bernie Sanders’ Mittens Meme

Overview

The Bernie Sanders Mittens Meme originated from an image of the Vermont senator sitting with crossed legs, bundled in a winter coat and homemade mittens during the 2021 U.S. presidential inauguration. The photo’s cozy, relatable vibe quickly became a template for meme creators to insert Bernie into countless unexpected scenarios.

Key Details

- **True Meme Elements:**
The appeal lies in Sanders’ posture and attire, which stood out amid the formality of the inauguration. The image became a transparent layer to superimpose over iconic events, movies, or pop culture scenes.
- **Psychological Factors:**
This meme taps into the concept of *relatable discomfort*, showcasing a public figure who looks unimpressed and practical in a glamorous setting. It evoked warmth, humor, and the idea of “being over it,” especially amid the pandemic.
- **Social Influence:**
Shared widely across social media, the meme united people across political lines

through humor. It highlighted how ordinary moments can become iconic through public relatability.

- **Impact:**
The meme sparked discussions about fashion, class, and political branding. Sanders even used the viral image to sell merchandise and donated proceeds to charity, further cementing its legacy.

Response

- **Widespread Humor:** Audiences embraced the image as a refreshing break from political drama, portraying Sanders as grounded and authentic.
- **Cross-Generational Appeal:** The meme was appreciated across age groups and political spectrums, making it a rare unifying internet moment.
- **Criticism:** A minority viewed it as distracting from serious issues, arguing that it turned a significant political moment into a joke.

3.4.5 Case Study 5: “Gonna Tell My Kids” Meme

Overview

The “Gonna Tell My Kids” meme began as a humorous way to misattribute modern or pop culture references, usually accompanied by a caption stating, “Gonna tell my kids this was [famous person/event].” It plays on the idea of rewriting history with irony or exaggeration.

Key Details

- **True Meme Elements**
The meme involves posting a recognizable figure or event and labeling it as something else entirely—often sarcastic, nostalgic, or absurd. It gained traction for its simplicity and adaptability.
- **Psychological Factors**
It appeals to *memory distortion* and *playful fabrication*, mocking the way history is sometimes passed down inaccurately. It also connects with *generational pride* and *cultural satire*, poking fun at trends and icons.

- **Social Influence**

Used on Twitter and Instagram, it allowed users to reinterpret cultural narratives with humor. The meme format evolved into a storytelling tool for mocking generational storytelling or glamorizing niche references.

- **Impact**

The meme highlighted the fluid nature of memory and how pop culture is shared across generations. It was also used in political contexts, comparing present figures to historical icons.

Response

- **Creative Engagement:** People loved the creativity it encouraged, sharing absurd, hilarious reinterpretations of celebrities, influencers, and events.
- **Critical Conversations:** Some saw it as a way to critique how media manipulates historical memory or celebrity culture.
- **Pushback:** A few responses warned against the meme trivializing important events or reinforcing misinformation, even if humorously intended.

3.5 Delphi Method

Introduction

In today's media-driven society, the intersection between psychology and journalism is becoming increasingly critical. Media not only reports reality but also shapes perceptions, behaviors, and mental health awareness. This project explores the synergies between psychological principles and journalistic practice, using the Delphi Method to derive consensus from a panel of experts across relevant fields. The study involved training 13 students under the guidance of a diverse panel of professionals from psychology, media, law, and academia, aimed at creating an informed, ethically aware, and psychologically sensitive approach to journalism.

Why the Delphi Method?

The Delphi Method is a structured communication technique used to achieve a convergence of opinion among a group of experts on complex topics. It involves multiple rounds of questioning, feedback, and revision, maintaining anonymity and reflection in the decision-making process. For this project, it offered a powerful way to:

- Bring together interdisciplinary expertise.
- Allow for iterative refinement of student and expert contributions.
- Encourage consensus on best practices in the convergence of psychology and journalism.

Composition of the Expert Panel

A diverse and experienced group of nine professionals guided the project:

1. **Dr. Vennela – Consultant Psychiatrist:** Offered insights into psychological health, trauma, and its portrayal in media.

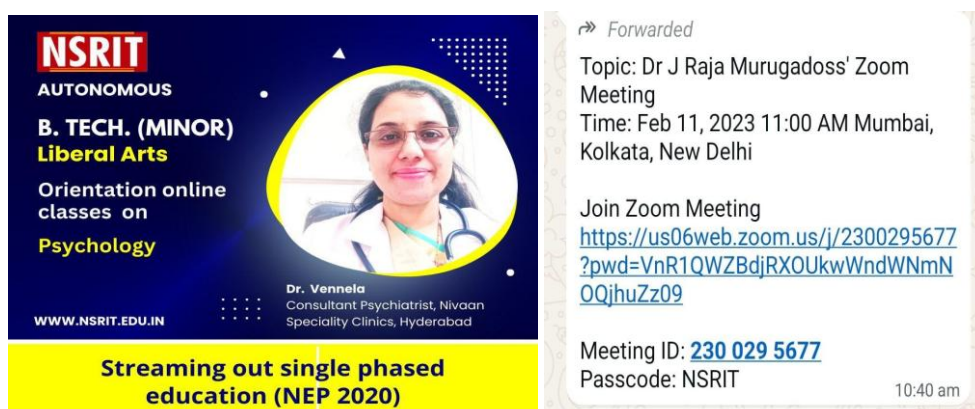


Fig 2: An Online session with Dr. Vennela

2. **Dr. P. J. Sudhakar – Additional Deputy (Journalism), Civil Services:** Brought a policy-level understanding of media operations and ethics.

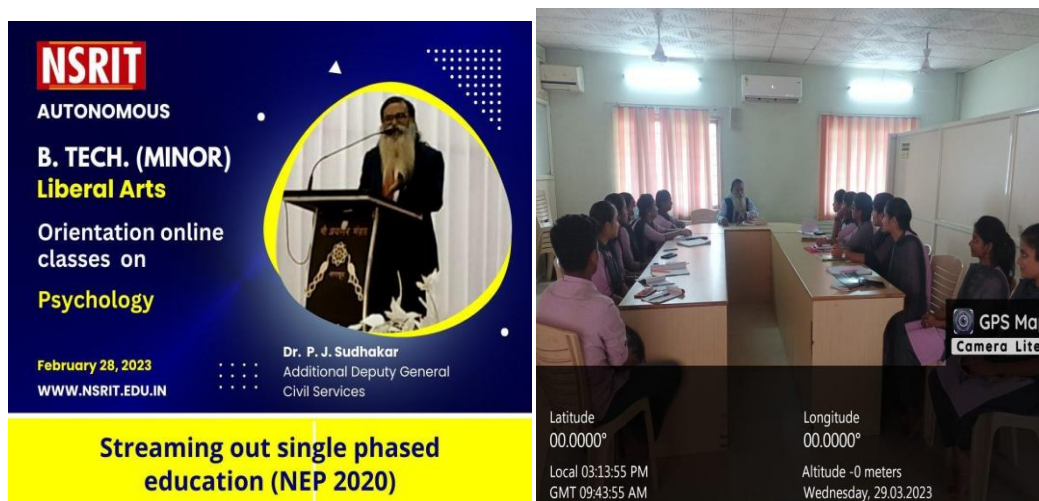


Fig 3: An Interaction with Dr. P.J. Sudhakar

3. Paramjeet Kaur – School Counsellor (MA in English and Psychology): Focused on developmental psychology and student mental well-being.



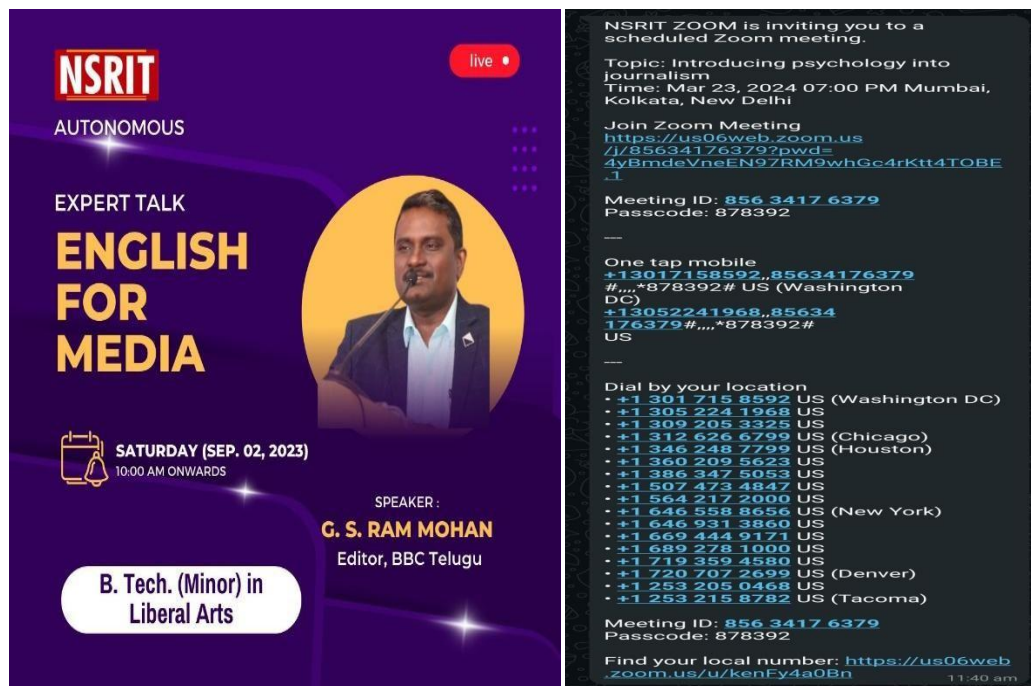
Fig 4: A Coffee Day With Paramjeet Kaur (MA in Psychology)

4. Dr. Rama Naga Hanuman Alapati – Chairman, PG Board of Studies in English, Andhra University: Bridged academic English studies and narrative construction in journalism.



Fig 5: An Interaction with Dr. Rama Naga Hanuman Alapati

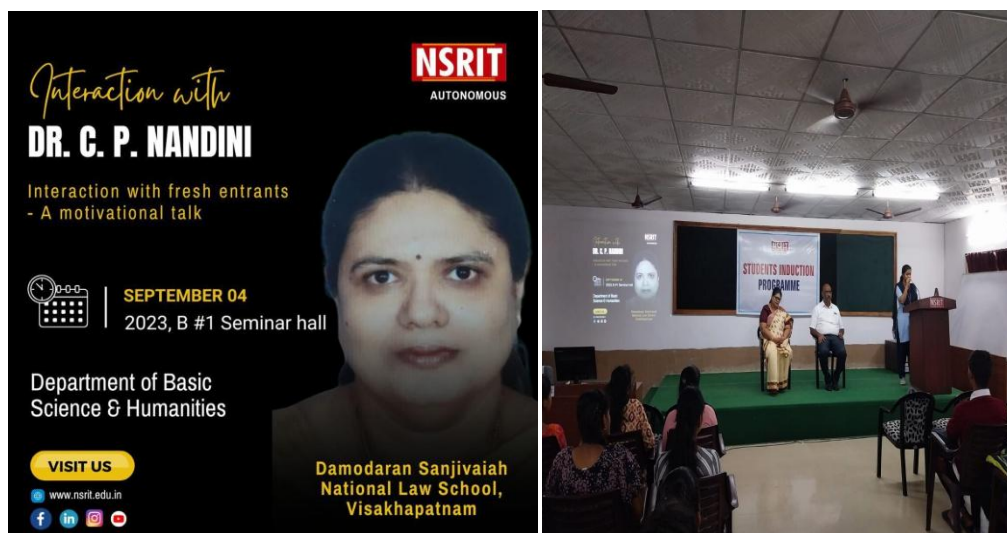
5. **G. S. Ram Mohan – Editor, BBC Telugu:** Provided real-world editorial experience and insights into ethical reporting.



The image is a composite of two parts. The left part is a purple promotional poster for an NSRIT event. It features the NSRIT logo at the top left, with 'AUTONOMOUS' below it. The main text reads 'EXPERT TALK ENGLISH FOR MEDIA'. A circular inset shows a portrait of G. S. Ram Mohan. Below this, it says 'SATURDAY (SEP. 02, 2023) 10:00 AM ONWARDS'. At the bottom, it mentions 'B. Tech. (Minor) in Liberal Arts' and 'SPEAKER: G. S. RAM MOHAN Editor, BBC Telugu'. The right part is a screenshot of a Zoom invitation from NSRIT ZOOM. It states: 'NSRIT ZOOM is inviting you to a scheduled Zoom meeting. Topic: Introducing psychology into journalism Time: Mar 23, 2024 07:00 PM Mumbai, Kolkata, New Delhi'. It provides a Zoom link, Meeting ID: 856 3417 6379, and Passcode: 878392. It also lists various international dial-in numbers for different locations like Washington DC, Chicago, Houston, New York, Denver, and Tacoma.

Fig 6: An online Interaction with G. S. Ram Mohan – Editor, BBC

6. **Dr. C. P. Nandhini – Professor, National Law School, Visakhapatnam:** Discussed media laws, rights, and legal accountability.



The image is a composite of two parts. The left part is a black promotional poster for an NSRIT event. It features the NSRIT logo at the top right, with 'AUTONOMOUS' below it. The main text reads 'Interaction with DR. C. P. NANDINI'. Below this, it says 'Interaction with fresh entrants - A motivational talk'. A circular inset shows a portrait of Dr. C. P. Nandhini. Below this, it says 'SEPTEMBER 04 2023, B #1 Seminar hall'. At the bottom, it mentions 'Department of Basic Science & Humanities' and 'Damodaran Sanjivaiah National Law School, Visakhapatnam'. The right part is a photograph of a seminar in progress. A woman in a yellow sari is standing at a podium on a stage, addressing an audience. A man in a white shirt is seated next to her. A screen in the background displays the text 'STUDENTS INDUCTION PROGRAMME'.

7. Ganapathi – Media Consultant, Journalist, and English Teacher (Sweden):
Engaged in a virtual interaction focusing on global perspectives and pedagogy.

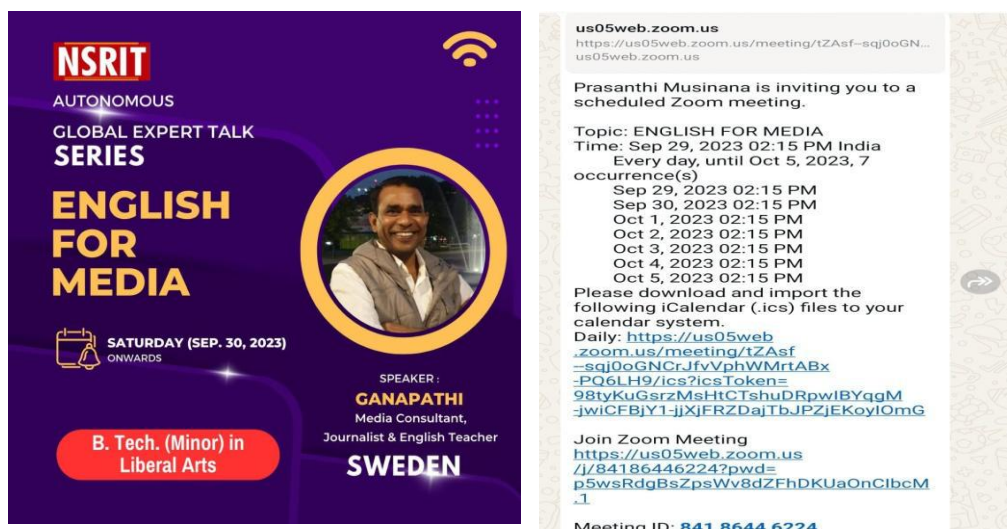


Fig 8: An Online Interaction with Ganapathi

8. Sumit Bhattacharjee – Chief and Sub Editor, The Hindu, Visakhapatnam:
Conducted a personal interaction about investigative reporting and narrative framing.



Fig 9: An Interaction with Sumit Bhattacharjee

9. Ravindra Reddy Gajjala – Behavioural and Communication Coach, Counselling Psychologist, Relation ship, Parenting, career and Work



Fig 10: A Quick Interaction With Ravindra Reddy Gajjala

Delphi Method Implementation

Round 1: Expert Training and Input

Each expert conducted specialized sessions for the 13 students, offering training in their respective domains.

Key topics included:

- Psychological trauma and ethical sensitivity in storytelling.
- Media ethics, misinformation, and psychological impact.
- English language precision in journalism.
- Legal boundaries in journalism.
- Cultural competence and global journalism standards.

Round 2: Student Synthesis and Initial Reporting

We submitted written reflections or short proposals based on what they had learned.

Emerging themes included:

- The role of language in shaping psychological narratives in news.
- Ethical reporting on suicide, mental health, and trauma.
- Influence of media on adolescent psychology.
- Legal responsibilities and psychological consequences of fake news.
- Journalistic burnout and the importance of psychological resilience.
- These submissions served as the foundation for feedback.

Round 3: Expert Feedback and Consensus Building

Anonymized summaries of student reflections were sent back to the expert panel. Experts provided written feedback through structured questionnaires and reflective prompts.

Key feedback questions:

- Which student themes reflect emerging concerns in your field?
- What practices do you recommend for ethically reporting psychological content?
- How should journalism education integrate mental health training?

Through this iterative process, areas of consensus emerged:

- The need for interdisciplinary education blending journalism, psychology, and ethics.
- The importance of trauma-informed journalism and appropriate language use.
- The value of reflective practice for journalists to maintain psychological well-being.
- The responsibility of media in shaping mental health narratives responsibly.

Outcomes of the Delphi Method

The study resulted in multiple practical and theoretical outcomes:

1. Educational Framework Proposal

A model was proposed for a journalism curriculum that includes:

- Psychology of communication and trauma.
- Narrative ethics and language analysis.
- Legal literacy in media.
- Mindfulness and mental health support for journalists.

2. Research Insights

The expert consensus validated the importance of:

- Informed reporting on sensitive psychological topics.
- Better training for journalists in identifying and mitigating the psychological impact of their work.
- Ethical awareness in both written and visual storytelling.

3. Student Growth

The 13 participating students reported enhanced:

- Critical thinking across disciplines.
- Empathy in reporting.
- Awareness of their responsibilities as future media professionals.

Conclusion

This project demonstrated the power of the Delphi Method in bringing together experts and students from various fields to collaboratively explore complex, interdisciplinary topics. By engaging deeply with themes in psychology, English studies, and journalism, and synthesizing expert opinion through a structured Delphi process, the project not only fostered academic growth but also proposed a forward-thinking model for responsible, informed media practice.

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DATA ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

4.1 Questionnaire

To collect primary data for this research, a structured survey titled “**Memes: The Modern Influence on Public Perception**” was developed using Google Forms. The primary objective of the questionnaire was to explore how individuals engage with internet memes and how these interactions influence their psychological responses and public attitudes. The questionnaire was designed to be completed in approximately 5 minutes and was divided into six focused sections to cover various dimensions of meme consumption and perception.

1. Demographic Information

This section gathered essential background data to assess the influence of demographic factors on meme engagement and interpretation. Participants were asked to provide the following details:

- **Age:**
 - Under 18
 - 18–24
 - 25–34
 - 35–44
 - 45 or above
- **Gender:**
 - Male
 - Female
 - Non-binary
 - Prefer not to say
- **Level of Education:**

- High school or less
- Some college
- Bachelor's degree
- Master's degree
- Doctoral degree
- **Frequency of Social Media Use:**
 - Rarely
 - Occasionally
 - Frequently
 - Daily
 - Multiple times a day

2. General Meme Consumption

This section aimed to understand participants' exposure to and interaction with memes on various platforms. Key questions included:

- How often do you come across memes on platforms like Instagram, Twitter (X), or Facebook?
- How often do you share or repost memes?
- What types of memes do you engage with most (e.g., humorous, political, satirical, relatable)?
- What emotions do memes most often evoke in you (e.g., amusement, discomfort, inspiration)?

3. Psychological Influence

Participants were asked to reflect on how memes affect their thinking and emotions. This section included:

- To what extent do memes influence your opinions on political or social issues?
- Do you believe memes contribute to the spread of misinformation or bias?

4. Emotional and Cognitive Responses

This section examined the psychological effects of meme interaction, such as emotional stimulation and cognitive interpretation:

- Do you experience strong emotional reactions (e.g., outrage, laughter, empathy) to certain memes?
- Have you ever changed your opinion on a public issue due to a meme?
- Do memes make you feel more informed or more skeptical about current events?

5. Social and Cultural Context

Participants were asked to consider how memes relate to their social identity and peer influence:

- Do you share memes based on group relevance or social acceptance?
- Have memes ever sparked discussions or debates within your friend group or online communities?
- Do you think memes reflect or shape cultural and societal values?

6. Open-Ended Reflections

This final section provided space for participants to share personal experiences or reflections:

- Describe a meme that significantly influenced your opinion or sparked a meaningful conversation.

4.2 Response Analysis

The survey responses were predominantly from individuals in the 18–24 age group, reflecting a younger demographic that is highly active in meme consumption and social media engagement. The gender distribution was fairly balanced, and most respondents held a Bachelor's degree, indicating a relatively well-educated audience. This aligns with the study's objective of analyzing how informed, digitally literate individuals perceive and are influenced by memes in shaping public opinion.

In terms of meme interaction frequency, the majority of participants reported encountering or sharing memes daily or several times a week, signifying their routine integration into digital communication. Instagram, X This highlights the widespread accessibility and reach of meme culture across various digital ecosystems.

When asked about their reasons for engaging with memes, the top motivators included entertainment, relatability, and the ability to express complex ideas humorously. Many respondents also mentioned that memes offer a way to cope with stress or negativity, or to stay informed about current events in a lighthearted way. These insights suggest that memes serve both emotional and informational functions, allowing users to process and reflect on societal issues through humor and satire.

Regarding emotional and cognitive impact, participants largely reported that memes often evoke amusement, agreement, or curiosity. A notable portion indicated that certain memes have influenced their opinions particularly on topics like politics, social justice, and pop culture. While most respondents viewed memes as harmless or humorous, some acknowledged that memes can oversimplify serious topics or reinforce biases, particularly when shared without context.

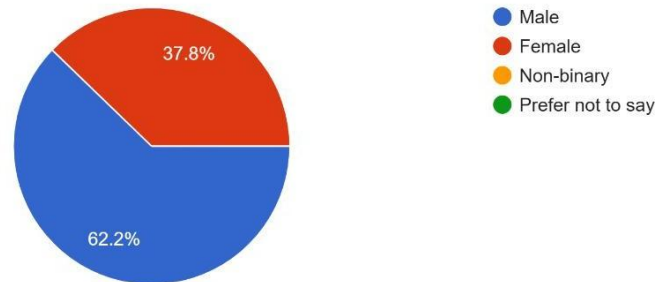
In terms of social influence, many participants shared that they often discuss memes with peers or use them as conversation starters. When asked whether memes can shape public perception or influence societal narratives, the majority agreed that memes play a subtle yet powerful role in shaping opinions, particularly among younger audiences.

Some recounted instances where a meme sparked personal reflection or motivated them to research a topic further. Others shared concerns about misinformation or stereotyping through memes but emphasized their value in fostering community, humor, and engagement.

4.3 Charts & Graphs

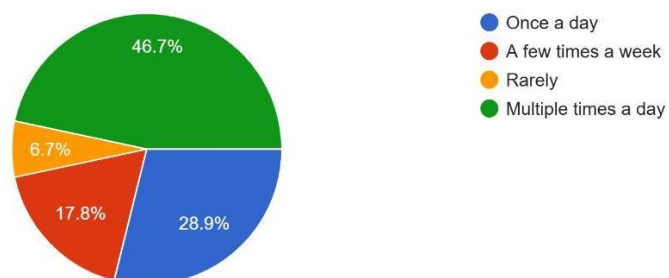
What is your gender?

45 responses



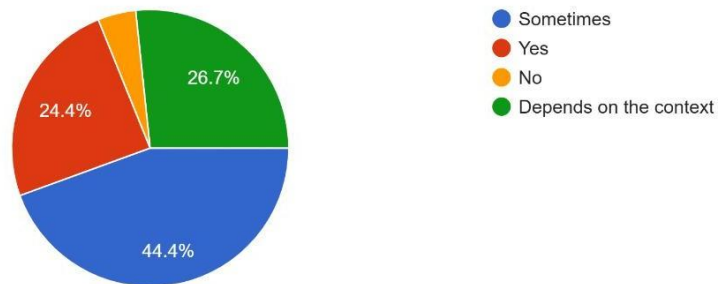
How often do you encounter memes online?

45 responses



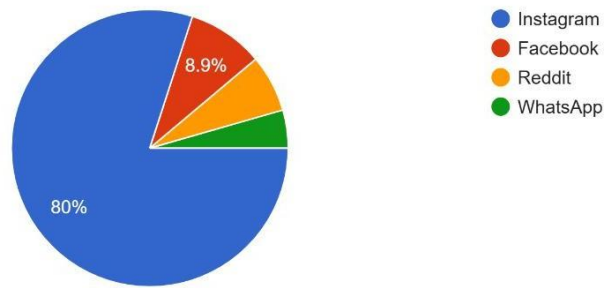
Do you think memes are a reliable source of information?

45 responses



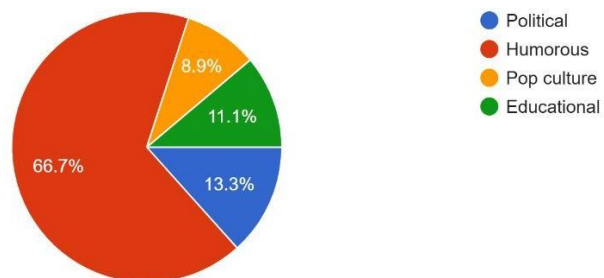
Where do you mostly see memes?

45 responses



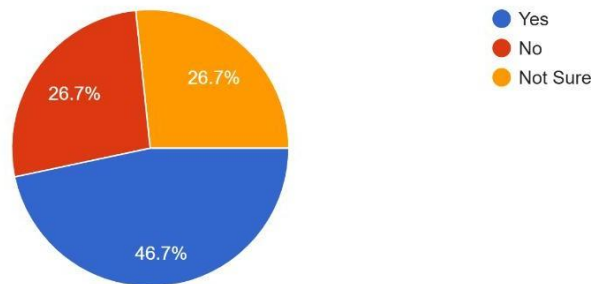
What kind of memes do you usually view?

45 responses



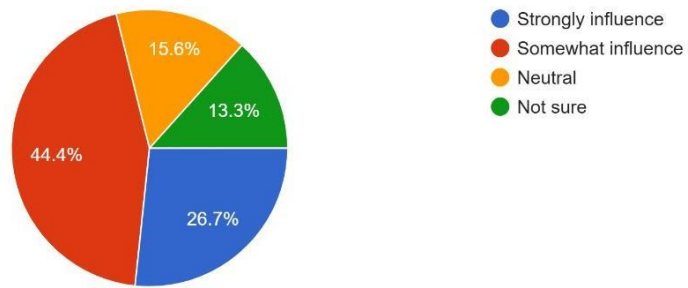
Have you ever changed your view about a topic after seeing a meme?

45 responses



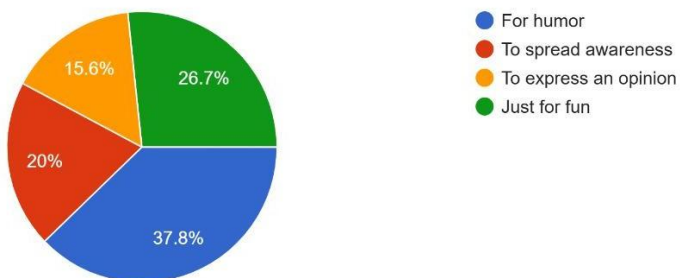
How do you feel memes shape public opinion on political or social issues?

45 responses



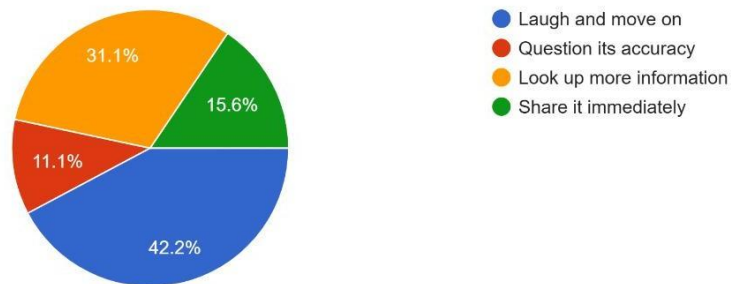
Why do you share memes?

45 responses



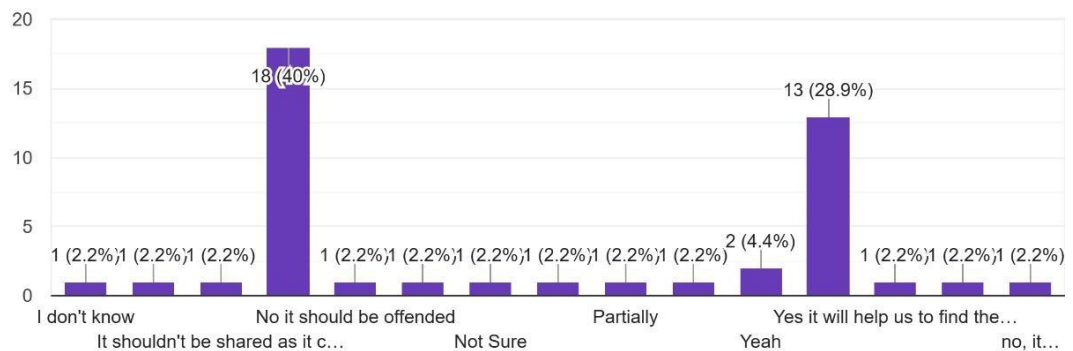
When you see a meme about a current event, what's your first reaction?

45 responses



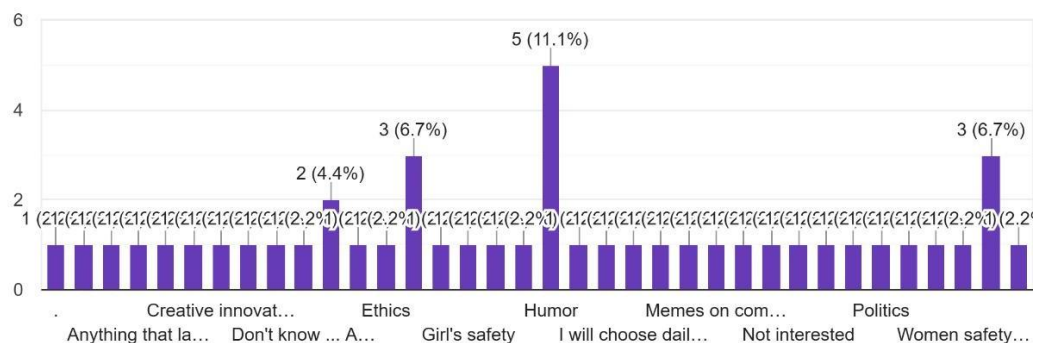
If a meme spreads misinformation but is funny, should it still be shared?

45 responses



If you were to create a meme that influences people positively, what topic would you choose and why?

45 responses



How would you describe the role memes play in shaping public opinion today?

45 responses

engaging, and often humorous, which makes them more likely to go viral.

Few memes influence very badly and few gives u information

Just a source of spreading information.

I don't know

Creating awareness

Very important as most of our generation likes to invest there time online

good

Ha

Fun

It's complicated

In your opinion, what psychological need do memes fulfill for their audience?

Sample responses from the questionnaire revealed a variety of psychological functions that memes serve:

1. **Curiosity** “Memes make me curious about trending issues or hidden meanings. Sometimes a meme makes me Google the backstory just to get the joke.”
2. **Social Connection** “Sharing memes is my way of bonding with friends and staying in touch. It keeps our chats fun and alive.”
3. **Entertainment & Humor** “I scroll through memes after a long day they’re hilarious, and it’s the quickest way to unwind and feel better.”
4. **Validation & Identity Expression** “It’s nice seeing memes that reflect exactly how I feel it’s like someone gets me without needing to say much.”
5. **Emotional Regulation** “Memes are like emotional therapy sometimes. A dark or sarcastic meme helps me laugh through something stressful.”
6. **Critical Thinking & Satire** “Some memes, especially political ones, actually make me think deeper about social issues like a funny take on serious matters.”

7. **Information & Awareness** “I’ve learned about news and issues through memes before I saw it in the headlines. They’re oddly informative.”
8. **Coping Mechanism** “Memes about stress, burnout, or anxiety make me feel less alone. They make tough feelings feel normal and shared.”

Please share any personal thoughts, experiences, or reasons behind your interest (or disinterest) in meme content.

1. I love how memes say things we’re all thinking but rarely say out loud—it’s honest, raw, and hilarious.
2. Memes help me understand the mood of the internet. I feel more connected to trends and conversations.
3. Honestly, I share memes more than I talk sometimes. They’re my social currency.
4. Sometimes memes are the only thing that gets me through a tough day—they’re quick hits of humor. “I’ve seen memes change opinions. A well-made meme can go viral and spark debates. That’s real power.
5. I enjoy memes because they mix humor with serious messages. It’s like getting educated without realizing it.
6. Not all memes are good—some spread false info or stereotypes. But when used right, they’re an amazing communication tool.
7. Memes are my way of understanding how people view politics, gender, mental health, and everything in between. They’re tiny but impactful reflections of society.

FINDINGS & RECOMMENDATIONS

Key Findings

This research investigated how internet memes influence public perception and psychological responses. Based on collected survey data and participant reflections, the following insights were observed

1. High Meme Engagement Among Digital Natives

The majority of respondents were from the 18–24 age group, confirming that young adults are the most active consumers and creators of memes. Most participants reported daily interaction with meme content across platforms like Instagram, Twitter, and Facebook.

2. Memes as a Source of Humor, Connection, and Coping

Emotional responses to memes were overwhelmingly positive, with humor and amusement being the most common. Participants also reported that memes helped them process difficult topics or bond with others over shared cultural references.

3. Influence on Opinions and Awareness

A significant portion of respondents acknowledged that memes had, at times, shaped their views on political, societal, or cultural issues. Memes often act as simplified commentary that influences public sentiment—particularly around trending topics.

4. Memes Reinforce Group Identity and Social Belonging

Respondents shared that memes were often discussed with friends or online communities. This social sharing promotes a sense of belonging and group identity, especially when memes reflect shared values or humor styles.

5. Cognitive Bias and Confirmation

Many participants admitted they are more likely to share memes that align with their personal beliefs or political views. This suggests that memes may reinforce existing biases rather than challenge perspectives.

6. Ethical Concerns and Context Sensitivity

When asked about the potential harms of memes, respondents expressed concern over content that spreads misinformation, stereotypes, or trivializes serious issues. Most agreed that while memes are meant to entertain, creators should be aware of the context and impact.

7. Open-Ended Reflections Show Thoughtful Engagement

Responses revealed that users appreciate memes not just for entertainment but for their commentary, creativity, and the way they reflect real-world emotions. Some shared experiences of how a particular meme made them reflect on personal beliefs or prompted conversations in their social circles.

5.2 Suggestions

1. Promote Digital Literacy Around Memes

Educators and media platforms should encourage critical consumption of memes helping users distinguish between satire, misinformation, and genuine commentary.

2. Encourage Ethical Meme Creation

Memers and influencers should be mindful of the content they produce or share, especially when dealing with sensitive topics like mental health, politics, or social justice.

3. Use Memes for Positive Advocacy

Memes can be a powerful tool to spread awareness about important social causes. Institutions can leverage meme culture to engage younger audiences with educational or civic campaigns.

4. Facilitate Conversations on Meme Interpretation

Including meme analysis in communication, media studies, or psychology courses can help students better understand their emotional, cultural, and rhetorical impact.

5. Create Community Guidelines for Responsible Sharing

Social media platforms could implement community tools that allow users to flag memes that are misleading or harmful, encouraging responsible engagement.

6. Encourage Diverse Representation in Memes

Representation in memes should reflect global and cultural diversity, avoiding stereotypes and promoting inclusive narratives.

7. Support Research on Meme Psychology

Further interdisciplinary studies should explore how memes affect memory, perception, emotional health, and social cognition across different demographics.

8. Foster Humor with Responsibility

While humor is a key function of memes, meme creators should be aware of the thin line between satire and insensitivity—especially when engaging with marginalized or vulnerable communities.

CONCLUSION

This study has explored the psychological, emotional, and social impact of memes as a modern form of media communication. Memes have become a defining feature of modern communication, evolving far beyond their humorous origins. They are now tools of expression, commentary, and reflection shaping how individuals perceive reality. Memes were consumed not just for laughter but also for insight, solidarity, and social commentary. Psychologically, memes fulfill a range of emotional and cognitive needs. They offer a sense of connection, acting as social glue in online communities.

Many respondents noted that memes help them process complex or sensitive topics.

From political satire to mental health awareness, memes are entry points for deeper conversations. They also provide a coping mechanism, transforming stress or fear into shared humor.

Importantly, memes influence how audiences interpret news, culture, and current events. They condense opinions into digestible visuals, shaping narratives with speed and reach. Yet, audiences are not passive they engage critically, sharing or rejecting memes based on personal values. This active participation makes memes a unique hybrid of media and conversation.

Socially, memes are a form of crowd-sourced storytelling that reflect collective sentiment. They capture public mood anger, hope, frustration, or unity in a single post or image. In this way, memes act as cultural snapshots, archiving how society reacts to the moment.

As digital culture continues to grow, so will the impact of meme-based communication. This influence reaches into politics, education, mental health, and identity formation. To ignore meme culture is to overlook a central part of how the public now thinks and feels.

In conclusion, memes are more than digital jokes they are modern symbols of meaning. They deserve thoughtful study, creative appreciation, and responsible engagement.

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